

TOPIC 02

The case for change

Prove the problem before you propose the fix

The consultant's first real job

diagnose before you prescribe

- You can speak cloud now — now you do the diagnosis.
- Find out where the organisation is, where it needs to be, and the gap between.
- Three moves: align to strategy → describe the current state → expose the gaps.
- These three become the opening sections of the business case you'll build.

A case for change is evidence, not opinion

- It answers three questions, in order:
 - Where does the organisation want to go? — strategy
 - Where is it now? — current state
 - What's missing to get there? — gaps
- You're not choosing a solution yet — you're proving the problem is real and worth solving.
- Solutions come next. Diagnose before you prescribe.

01

SECTION

Strategic alignment

tie the initiative to the organisation's goals

Start with strategy

or the board won't fund it

- A board funds change that moves the organisation toward its own stated goals.
- Lead by showing the initiative serves the strategy – not technology for its own sake.
- Strategic alignment = “here's what they said they want; here's how this delivers it.”
- It's the “why this, why now” that earns everything that follows.

Read a strategic plan in three layers

- Business objectives — where the whole organisation is going
 - e.g. grow students 15%/yr, expand nationally
- ICT goals / objectives — how ICT supports that
 - e.g. reduce in-house dependency; 99.9% for critical systems
- Initiatives — the planned actions
 - e.g. move suitable on-site systems to the cloud
- Trace your initiative up these layers — pull only what's material.

Add the outside view

industry context

- A plan doesn't exist in a vacuum — compare it to where the industry is heading.
- Trends that matter: cloud adoption · managed services · OPEX over CAPEX · resilience.
- Name both directions:
 - Alignment — the plan matches industry direction (strengthens the case)
 - Divergence — the plan lags or differs (a risk, or an opportunity to flag)

What good looks like

- Every claim cited to the plan (e.g. “ICT Strategic Plan – ICT Goals”).
- Material items only – not the whole plan recited.
- Traces the initiative up to a real organisational goal.
- Alignment and divergence both named – balanced, not cheerleading.

ACTIVITY

Write a Strategic Alignment section

- In your working copy of the Business Case, write the Strategic Alignment section for moving the Accounting System (Ledgerline).
- Remember to:
 - Read YAT's ICT Strategic Plan.
 - Which ICT goals/objectives does this migration serve? Trace up to a business objective – cite them.
 - Add one or two points of industry context – where's the sector heading?
 - Note alignment and divergence.
- ~½ page.
- ⚠ Argue alignment through the ICT goals, and name the weaker links honestly. That is the analysis.



~20 min, then we discuss

Key takeaways

Section 1 · Strategic alignment

Open with strategy: tie the initiative to the organisation's own stated goals.

Three layers — business objectives / ICT goals / initiatives; pull only what's material.

Add the outside view; name alignment and divergence.

Cite everything. Strategy is the “why this, why now”.

02

SECTION

Current-state synthesis

synthesis, not transcription

Current state is synthesis, not transcription

- Summarise the current environment in your own words, focused on what's material to this decision.
- The board needs the picture that explains why change is needed — not a copy of the IT docs.
- Distil it down; don't transcribe it.

The relevance filter

keep vs drop

- KEEP (if it bears on the decision):
 - platform & stack · age / condition / capacity · availability today · dependencies & integrations · constraints · pain points
- DROP:
 - detail that doesn't move the decision (printer counts, unrelated systems)
- A good current state quietly surfaces the limitations that motivate the change.

How to distil

- Read the source docs — environment overview, server/app specs, consultation notes.
- For each fact ask: “does this affect the renew-vs-migrate decision?” If no, cut it.
- Re-state what's left in plain language, grouped: platform · workload · dependencies · condition/risk.
- Aim $\sim\frac{1}{2}$ page. No copy-paste.

ACTIVITY

Add the Current State section

- In your working copy of the Business Case, add the Current State section for the Accounting System (Ledgerline).
- Remember to:
 - Use the Accounting application spec, server specs, operational costing, the ICT Environment Overview, and the consultation notes.
 - Cover: platform & stack · workload (incl. month-end / EOFY peaks) · integrations (AD, O365, LMS fee-status, payroll, banking) · condition & constraints.
- ~½ page.
- ⚠ Material only — synthesise in your own words, no verbatim copying.



~20 min, then we discuss

Key takeaways

Section 2 · Current state

Own words, material facts only — synthesis beats transcription.

Filter every fact against “does it affect the decision?”

Surface the limitations that set up the gap analysis.

03

SECTION

Gap analysis

bridges “want” and “have”

Gap analysis bridges “want” and “have”

- It bridges where we want to be (strategy + requirements) and where we are (current state).
- It makes the problem concrete and measurable.
- It hands the next stage a list of changes to evaluate.
- No gap → no case.

The gap table

one row per objective

Objective	Current	Desired	Gap	Opportunity	Proposed change
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Objective/Desired ← Strategic Alignment + requirements · Current ← your Current State · Proposed change = the seed of the options you'll weigh next.

Anatomy of a good row

one objective, traced end to end

Field	Example
Objective	"reduce dependency on in-house server infrastructure"
Current	single ageing on-prem server, owned and maintained in-house
Desired	no in-house server to own / patch / replace
Gap	full reliance on end-of-life hardware the organisation must run itself
Opportunity	move to a managed / cloud platform
Proposed change	evaluate migrating the workload to the cloud (→ next topic)

Traceable both ways — objective came from the plan, current from your Current State.

ACTIVITY

Build the Gap Analysis

- In your working copy of the Business Case, add the Gap Analysis for the Accounting System (Ledgerline)
 - a table of at least 3 rows.
- Remember to draw objectives from your Strategic Alignment work + the migration requirements, e.g.:
 - reduce in-house infrastructure dependency (ageing server)
 - business-hours availability $\geq 99.5\%$ (RPO $\leq 1\text{h}$ / RTO ≤ 1 business day)
 - keep financial data onshore + 7-year retention
 - size for month-end / EOFY peaks without year-round over-provisioning
- Fill every column: objective $\rightarrow$ current $\rightarrow$ desired $\rightarrow$ gap $\rightarrow$ opportunity $\rightarrow$ proposed change.
- ⚠ Each row must trace back to a real objective and your current-state facts.



~25 min, then we discuss

Key takeaways

Section 3 · Gap analysis

Gap analysis = desired (strategy + requirements) vs current (your synthesis).

One row per objective; fill all six columns; keep it traceable.

The “proposed change” column feeds straight into the options analysis next.

From diagnosis to evaluation

You've built the case for change: strategy → current state → gaps.

That's the first half of a business case — it proves the problem is real and worth solving.

Your “proposed changes” aren't decisions yet — they're candidates.

Next: weigh the options, cost them, assess the risk — turning the case for change into a recommendation.

You practised on the Accounting System; the same moves carry to whatever engagement lands on your desk.